

Run of show

Sat Sep 26 · Seneca Ave & Palmetto St · rain date Sat Oct 3

0:00	Gather	Seneca Ave & Palmetto St. Hand out packets by group.
0:05	Opening	Read it. End on: three predictions, by the clock.
0:10	Split	Four bearings. Everyone walks 15 out, then turns around.
0:25	Turnaround	Wherever they are. Nobody has to reach a landmark.
0:40	Back at the start	Regroup. Guesses on the chart before any numbers.
0:50	The reveal	North and south have real numbers. East and west don't.
1:05	Walk to the cafe	Abracadabra Magic Cafe.
1:15	Close	The gradient, the \$79M, then the question. Stop talking.

The rule that holds it together

Everyone walks 15 minutes out, then turns around.

Time-boxed, not destination-boxed. Holding walk-time constant is what makes direction the only thing that varies — and it means east and west never need measuring. Whatever they reach in 15 minutes is the data point.

The four bearings

The packet does not print any of this. They are predicting.

NORTH

Palmetto → Woodward → Putnam

15.8 min: just short of Fresh Pond Rd

FALLS

\$2,083 → \$1,913

SOUTH

Seneca → Gates Ave

15.4 min: about at Knickerbocker Av

RISES, slightly

\$2,083 → \$2,116

WEST

Seneca → Grover Cleveland Pk → Hart

~13 min (map read)

NO PREDICTION

the live experiment

EAST

Seneca, eastbound

~15 min (map read)

NO PREDICTION

the live experiment

The wrinkle: the south group passes Myrtle-Wyckoff around minute 7

That is not an M-only station — it's the L transfer the analysis had to special-case. In the model's terms their middle prediction lands near a local maximum distance from any M-only station, where the model wants a dip and the observed rent shows a rise. Don't hide the gap. It is the confound this walk exists to probe: better transit vs. distance from the M-only cluster.

The reveal

Guesses on the chart first. Numbers second.

Observed median rent within 0.4 mi

West to east along the line

Central Av	\$2,278
Myrtle-Wyckoff	\$2,134
Knickerbocker Av	\$2,116
Seneca Av (start)	\$2,083
Forest Av	\$1,926
Fresh Pond Rd	\$1,913

Matched to their three stops

	min 1	~min 7	~min 15
North	\$2,083	\$1,926	\$1,913
South	\$2,083	\$2,134	\$2,116

North falls ~\$170 over the same fifteen minutes that south rises ~\$33.

Say these three things

- **Opposite directions, opposite answers.**

Same fifteen minutes: north falls about \$170, south rises about \$33. That is the whole walk in one line.

- **The drop isn't linear.**

North loses \$157 in the first seven minutes and only \$13 in the next eight. Steepest close in — what a decay model predicts, and what nobody guesses.

- **The south side is noisier than it looks.**

Myrtle-Wyckoff and Knickerbocker swap order depending on the radius. The honest read is “rising, then flat.” Don't over-claim that dip at minute 15.

Then the close

Rent falls about half a percent per minute you walk away from an M-only station.

Then the \$79M, then the question. Say the question last and stop talking.

Answers

“Is this StreetEasy?”

No. Census ACS — the government asks people what they actually pay. Rent plus utilities, averaged over 2020–2024, and mostly people already living here, not what's listed today. That makes it lower than a new lease, and more honest about what the neighborhood costs.

“Why only the M?”

These six stations are M-only — they lose through-service to Manhattan overnight and shrink to a shuttle. Distance to every other nearby station is held fixed in the model, so the number means ‘near this tier,’ not ‘near some train.’

“Myrtle-Wyckoff is on the M though.”

It is, but it's also the L transfer — so it's a control, not part of the M-only cluster. The transit feed lists it as two rows, one per line, and reading it naively makes it look M-only. That correction is the reason the south group's middle number behaves oddly.

“Does this prove the train causes it?”

No, and say so plainly. It's a description. Station locations and neighborhood change are tangled together and one snapshot can't separate them. That's exactly what east and west are for.

“What about public housing?”

Seven tracts in the sample sit near \$500 a month, fully renter-occupied — rent set as a share of income, not by the market. They can't respond to a subway at all. They're in the model, unadjusted. Worth raising as a question rather than an answer.

“How far does the effect reach?”

Inside a 30-minute walk it's basically flat — the gradient only shows up when the far tracts are in the picture. Don't oversell what happens within the first fifteen minutes; that's the part they just walked.

The number, said correctly

\$79 million a year — 69,047 renter households, about \$96/month each, compared to living twenty minutes away.

Say the comparison out loud. Without it the number means nothing: it's \$178M at 30 minutes.